MODULE 41 · FOUNDATIONS - ALL DOMAINS

AI and sustainability in project work

Using AI to automate, assist and augment, responsibly; and building sustainability into every stage of a project.

DOMAIN Cross-domain EXAM WEIGHT All domains MODULE 41 of 49

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Use AI as a capable assistant you check. Treat sustainability as a requirement, not a wish.

Automate, assist, augment

USE	WHAT AI DOES	EXAMPLE
Automate	Performs a routine task with little human effort	Transcribing meetings; filing actions to the tracker
Assist	Produces a first version that a person reviews	Drafting a status report or risk list for the PM to check
Augment	Extends what a person can see or analyse	Finding risk patterns across hundreds of past projects

ON THE EXAM

PMI describes project professionals using AI to automate, assist and augment their work. None removes accountability.

Where AI helps in project work

- **Drafting and summarising**: meeting notes, reports, first drafts of plans and user stories.
- **Analysing data**: spotting trends in schedule, cost, defects and flow metrics.
- **Risk and forecasting**: suggesting risks, testing scenarios, supporting estimates.
- **Finding knowledge**: searching lessons learned and documents in plain language.
- Most value comes from freeing time for the human work: leading, deciding, engaging.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> AI speeds up information work. The time it frees should go to people, judgement and relationships.

The risks of using AI

RISK	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Errors and invented facts	Confident, plausible, wrong: a date, a figure, a source
Confidentiality and privacy	Sensitive data pasted into an unapproved public tool
Bias	Recommendations that disadvantage some groups
Intellectual property	Unclear ownership of generated content; copied material
Over-reliance	Skills fade; nobody checks; judgement is outsourced
Security	New tools and integrations as routes for attack

ON THE EXAM

Every one of these is a risk to identify and manage, like any other project risk.

Using AI responsibly

- **Human accountability**: the person who uses the output owns it.
- **Verify** facts, numbers and sources against the original data before anything goes out.
- **Protect data**: use approved tools, and never put confidential or personal data into unapproved ones.
- **Be transparent** about AI use where it matters, and follow organisational policy.
- Set simple team guidelines: what AI may be used for, with which tools, and how it is checked.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Accountable, verified, protected, transparent. The Code's values applied to a new tool.

What AI can do, and what stays human

AI CAN

Speed up information work

- Draft, summarise, translate
- Analyse large amounts of data
- Suggest options and risks
- Answer questions from documents

THE PROJECT LEADER STILL

Leads, decides and is accountable

- Builds trust and motivates people
- Resolves conflict and negotiates
- Makes ethical judgements
- Owns decisions and their consequences

THE TIEBREAKER

On the exam, AI is never the answer to a people problem, and never the owner of a decision.

Introducing AI into a team

- Start with a **pilot** on a real, low-risk task, with volunteers.
- Agree **guidelines**: approved tools, allowed uses, and how output is checked.
- Address **concerns** openly, including worries about jobs and skills.
- **Measure** the value: time saved, quality, and whether people find it useful.
- It is an organisational change: module 39's approach applies.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Adopt AI like any change: pilot, guide, listen, measure. Neither mandate it nor ban it outright.

Projects that build AI

- **Data first**: the quality and availability of data decides what is possible.
- **Uncertain by nature**: results emerge through experiments, so adaptive approaches fit.
- **New risks**: model accuracy, bias, drift over time, explainability.
- **Regulation and ethics**: AI-specific laws and standards are emerging in many regions.
- PMI offers a pattern-based approach for planning AI projects; the principles here still apply.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> An AI project is a high-uncertainty project with data, ethics and regulatory risks. Plan it as one.

Sustainability: the triple bottom line

THREE DIMENSIONS

People, planet, prosperity

- People: workers, communities, users
- Planet: emissions, materials, waste, energy
- Prosperity: long-term economic value
- All three, not one at the others' expense

IN THE 2026 EXAM

Named in several tasks

- Planning: sustainability as critical information
- Quality: cost of quality and sustainability
- Compliance: sustainability requirements
- Risk: sustainability risks

THE TIEBREAKER

PMBOK 8's principle: integrate sustainability within all project areas. The outline names it in four tasks.

Sustainability across the life cycle

STAGE	SUSTAINABILITY QUESTIONS
Business case	What are the environmental and social effects, good and bad?
Requirements	What measurable sustainability targets apply?
Design	Which materials, energy use, durability and repairability?
Procurement	Do selection criteria and contracts include sustainability?
Delivery	How is waste, travel and energy on the project reduced?
Handover and end of life	What does it cost to run, and what happens when it is retired?

ON THE EXAM

Sustainability decided early is cheap. Sustainability added at the end is expensive, or impossible.

Measuring sustainability, and making trade-offs

- Measure it like any objective: a **baseline**, a **target**, and an **owner**.
- Common measures: carbon emissions, energy, waste, water, social value.
- Compare options on **life-cycle cost**, not only purchase price.
- Where sustainability costs more now, make the trade-off **visible** and let the sponsor decide.
- Dropping sustainability quietly when budgets tighten breaks organisational commitments.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Sustainability trade-offs are decisions for the sponsor, with the life-cycle numbers on the table.

Honest sustainability claims

- **Greenwashing**: claiming more environmental benefit than the evidence supports.
- Every claim should be specific, measured and evidenced.
- Involve legal and compliance: many regions now regulate environmental claims.
- Honesty, from the Code of Ethics, applies to sustainability claims as much as to status reports.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> An overstated sustainability claim is a false claim. Evidence first, then words.

Project Lantern: AI and sustainability

- **Assist**: AI drafts meeting summaries and the weekly report; the PM checks every figure before sending.
- **Augment**: AI analysis of past booking data found which clinics most needed reminders.
- **Data rule**: patient data never enters general AI tools; only the approved, secured one.
- **Sustainability**: energy-efficient kiosks, a take-back scheme, and fewer patient journeys from better booking.
- Missed-appointment reduction was also reported as a social and environmental benefit, with evidence.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> AI used to assist and augment, with checks and data rules; sustainability measured and reported honestly.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
AI produced a draft plan, report or register	Treat it as a draft; verify; the PM is accountable
Sensitive data and a public AI tool	Approved tools only; follow data policy
Team divided about adopting AI	Pilot, guidelines, address concerns, measure value
Sustainable option costs more	Life-cycle analysis; sponsor decides the trade-off
A sustainability claim goes beyond the evidence	Raise it; claims must be accurate and evidenced
Asked which use of AI: automate, assist, augment	Routine task, reviewed draft, or new insight

ON THE EXAM

Check AI's work, protect data, and treat sustainability as a measured, honest requirement.

> A project manager used an AI tool to draft the project's initial risk register. The draft includes several plausible but irrelevant risks, and misses a supplier risk the team discussed last week.
>
> The sponsor wants the register by tomorrow.

What should the project manager do?

A. Treat the AI output as a draft: review it with the team, remove irrelevant risks, add known ones, and then submit it.

B. Submit the AI draft as it is, since the deadline is tomorrow.

C. Ban AI tools from project work in future.

D. Ask the AI tool to regenerate the register until it looks right.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Draft; review with team; fix; submit.

AI assists; the team validates; the PM stays accountable.

B Submit as it is.

Sends known errors and omissions to the sponsor.

C Ban AI.

Overreacts. The draft saved time; the missing step was review.

D Regenerate until it looks right.

Looking right is not being right. Only the team knows its real risks.

THE SIGNAL

AI drafts; people verify. Risk identification still needs the team.

> An analyst wants to paste six months of customer complaint records, including names and contact details, into a free public AI chatbot to find themes.
>
> The organisation has a data protection policy and an approved, secured AI tool.

What should the project manager do?

A Allow it, since finding themes will help the project.

B Ban all AI analysis of customer data.

C Use the approved tool, remove personal details where possible, and follow the data protection policy.

D Ask customers for permission before any analysis.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Allow the public tool.

Puts personal data into an unapproved tool; likely breaches policy and law.

B Ban AI analysis.

Loses real value. A compliant route exists.

C Approved tool, anonymised data, per policy.

Gets the value while protecting personal data.

D Ask every customer first.

Unnecessary if the approved route and policy already cover it.

THE SIGNAL

Sensitive data plus AI: approved tools, minimum personal data, and the policy. Not a free public tool.

> A PMO uses AI to analyse records from three hundred past projects. It finds a pattern no one had noticed: projects with more than two supplier handoffs overrun far more often.
>
> The PMO now uses this insight in risk planning.

Which kind of AI use is this?

A Automate

B Augment

C Assist

D Replace

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which kind of AI use is this?

A **Automate**

Automation performs a routine task. This found something new.

B **Augment**

Extends what people can see, revealing a pattern they could not.

C **Assist**

Assist drafts something a person would otherwise produce.

D **Replace**

Not one of PMI's categories; people still decide what to do with it.

THE SIGNAL

Routine task done: automate. Draft for review: assist. New insight humans could not reach: augment.

> A project manager wants the team to use an AI tool for meeting notes and action tracking. Some team members are enthusiastic; others worry it will be used to monitor them, or replace their roles.
>
> The organisation has approved the tool.

What should the project manager do?

A. Pilot it with volunteers, agree guidelines on use, discuss concerns openly, and measure the value.

B. Make the tool mandatory for all meetings from next week.

C. Drop the idea, since some team members are worried.

D. Let each person decide whether and how to use it, with no guidelines.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Pilot, guidelines, open discussion, measure.

Treats AI adoption as a change: involves people and tests the value.

B Mandate it.

Confirms the fears and breeds resistance.

C Drop it.

Gives up real value without addressing the concerns.

D No guidelines.

Inconsistent use, and the monitoring worry is never answered.

THE SIGNAL

Adopting AI is an organisational change. Pilot, guide, listen, measure.

> A building project can use low-carbon concrete that costs six percent more than standard concrete. The organisation has a public net-zero commitment.
>
> The budget is tight, and the sponsor has not yet been asked.

What should the project manager do?

A Choose standard concrete to protect the budget.

B Choose low-carbon concrete and absorb the extra cost quietly.

C Drop the net-zero target for this project.

D Present the options with their life-cycle cost and carbon impact, and let the sponsor decide.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Standard concrete.
Quietly overrides a public organisational commitment.

B Low-carbon, absorbed quietly.
Hides a cost trade-off the sponsor should see.

C Drop the target.
Not the project manager's commitment to drop.

D Present options; sponsor decides.
Makes the trade-off visible, with the evidence, to the right person.

THE SIGNAL

A sustainability trade-off with cost: show the life-cycle numbers and let the sponsor decide.

> The marketing team wants to describe a new product as 'carbon neutral'. The project's data shows only its manufacturing emissions are offset; transport and packaging are not.
>
> Launch materials are due to be printed next week.

What should the project manager do?

A Approve the claim, since marketing owns the launch materials.

B Stay silent, since claims are not the project's responsibility.

C Raise the gap with marketing, and involve legal or compliance so the claim is accurate and evidenced.

D Adjust the project's emissions data so the claim is supported.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Approve it.

Endorses a claim the project's own data does not support.

B Stay silent.

Knowing a claim is false and saying nothing fails the honesty value.

C Raise it; involve legal or compliance.

Honest, collaborative, and protects the organisation from a regulated false claim.

D Adjust the data.

Falsifying data. A serious ethics breach.

THE SIGNAL

A sustainability claim beyond the evidence is greenwashing. Raise it, with the evidence, before it goes out.

AI drafts; people decide. Sustainability is measured, not promised.